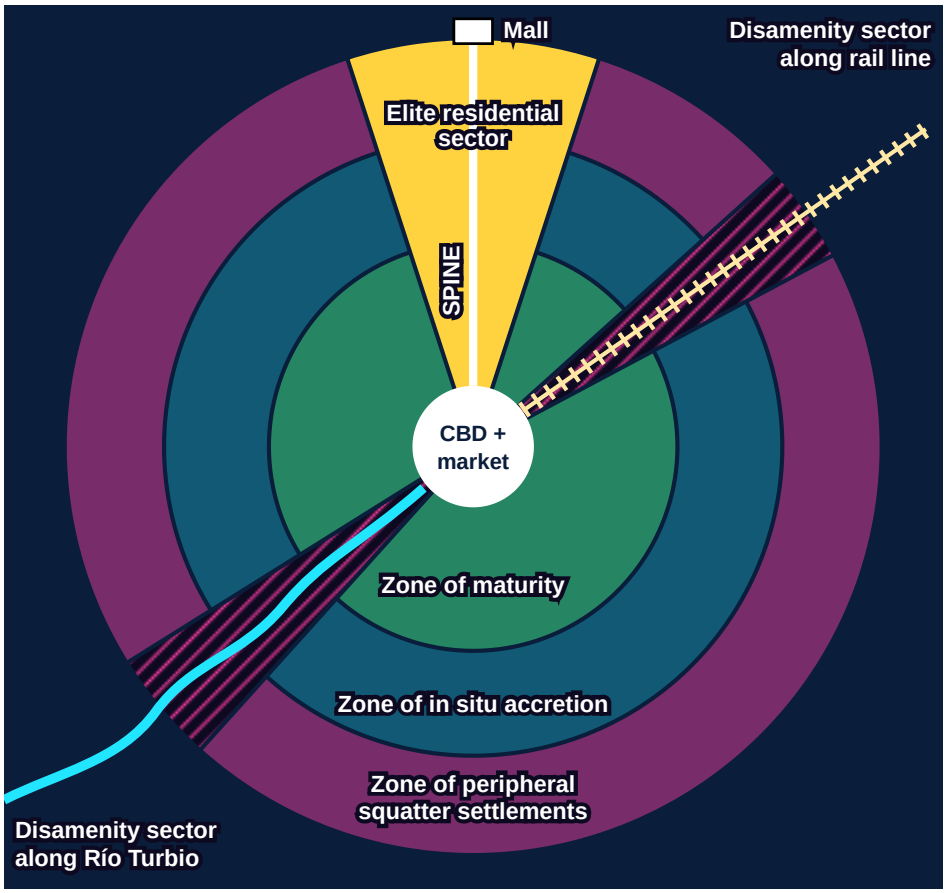
City of Contrasts

AP Human Geography · Unit 6 · Two stimuli (like Question 3) · 7 points · Teacher key · GeoArcade FRQ Tutor

Puerto Alba is the largest city of Valdoria, an invented Latin American country. Like many cities in developing countries, it has grown fast as people pour in from the countryside, and its rich and poor neighborhoods are arranged very differently from a typical U.S. city's.

Stimulus 1: Model of Puerto Alba, a Fictional Latin American City



CBD & market · Spine & elite residential sector · Zone of maturity · Zone of in situ accretion · Zone of peripheral squatter settlements · Disamenity sector · River · Rail line

Created for practice, based on the Griffin-Ford model. Puerto Alba and the Río Turbio are fictional. Not to scale.

Stimulus 2: The Four Largest Cities of Valdoria, 2000 and 2025

Rank	City	Population, 2000	Population, 2025	Rank-size rule prediction, 2025 (largest ÷ rank)
1	Puerto Alba	5,400,000	9,600,000	9,600,000
2	San Lucero	900,000	1,300,000	4,800,000
3	Aguasol	650,000	900,000	3,200,000
4	Tres Cerros	480,000	650,000	2,400,000

Valdoria, its cities, and all data are fictional, created for practice. Rank-size rule: city number n should have 1/n the population of the largest.

Class directions: label each part, and write Describe and Explain parts as T1- (your reason in general words), E2- (the specific proof), A3- (why it matters).

A. Identify the zone in Stimulus 1 where most of Puerto Alba's squatter settlements are located. IDENTIFY

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ANY ONE OF THESE:

- Names the zone of peripheral squatter settlements
- Locates it as the outermost ring at the city's edge

MODEL ANSWER

The zone of peripheral squatter settlements: the outermost ring at the edge of the city.

Common mistake: "Slums." That's a kind of housing, not a zone (the disamenity sectors have slums too). Name the zone: the zone of peripheral squatter settlements.

Why the model works: It names the zone (the zone of peripheral squatter settlements) and says where it is (the outermost ring).

B. Using Stimulus 1, describe the spine and the elite residential sector in Puerto Alba. DESCRIBE

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Describes the spine: a commercial boulevard out from the CBD
- Describes the elite sector: wealthy homes along the spine

MODEL ANSWER

T1- The spine is a commercial boulevard running out from the CBD, and the elite residential sector is the wedge of wealthy homes on both sides of it.
E2- In Stimulus 1, the spine runs north from the CBD to a mall at the edge, and the gold elite sector follows it through all three rings.
A3- Because the spine has the city's best shops, offices, and parks, the richest families live along it, so wealth forms a wedge, not a ring.

Common mistake: "The spine is on the north side of the city, and the elite residential sector is next to it." That only gives names and places. Describe what they ARE: a commercial boulevard, lined by the wealthiest homes.

Why the model works: It defines the spine, says who lives in the elite sector, and uses diagram details (north to a mall).

C. Explain ONE reason why wealthy residents of many Latin American cities live near the CBD and along the spine, unlike in many U.S. cities. EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Names a reason: services, amenities, jobs, safety, colonial tradition, or status
- Explains the contrast: the edge lacks services, while U.S. elites moved to suburbs

MODEL ANSWER

T1- Wealthy residents live near the CBD and spine because that is where the best services and amenities are.
E2- The center has reliable water, electricity, police, and the best shops and parks, while the squatter-settlement zone at the edge often lacks piped water and sewers.
A3- Because many squatter settlements at the edge lack reliable services, living near the center brings comfort, safety, and status, the opposite of the U.S., where cars and highways let the wealthy move out to suburbs.

Common mistake: "Rich people like to live in nice areas." Everyone does! Say WHAT makes the center nice (like better services) and contrast it with the edge or the U.S.

Why the model works: It names a reason (services), gives proof (water, police), and explains the U.S. contrast.

D. Using Stimulus 2, explain whether Puerto Alba is a primate city. Support your answer with data from the table. EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Compares table data: 9.6 vs. 1.3 million, or San Lucero's actual 1.3 million vs. its predicted 4.8 million
- Explains that it IS primate: more than twice the next city

MODEL ANSWER

T1- Yes, Puerto Alba is a primate city because it is far more than twice as large as Valdoria's second-largest city.
E2- Stimulus 2 shows Puerto Alba has 9,600,000 people, more than seven times San Lucero's 1,300,000, while the rank-size rule predicts 4,800,000 for San Lucero.
A3- Because every smaller city falls far below its prediction, and Puerto Alba has more than three times as many people as the other three cities combined, Valdoria's urban population is concentrated in one dominant city.

Common mistake: "Yes, Puerto Alba is a primate city because it is the largest city in Valdoria." Every country has a largest city, and there's no data. Prove it: 9,600,000 vs. 1,300,000.

Why the model works: It answers yes, proves it by comparing table numbers, and explains what primacy means.

E. Explain ONE cause of the rapid growth of squatter settlements on the edges of large cities in developing countries. EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Names a cause: rural-to-urban migration, population growth, or no affordable housing
- Explains the link: newcomers can't afford housing, so they build their own

MODEL ANSWER

T1- One cause is rapid rural-to-urban migration.
E2- Push factors like farm mechanization and rural poverty, plus pull factors like jobs and schools, send huge numbers of migrants to cities like Puerto Alba, which grew from 5,400,000 to 9,600,000 people since 2000.
A3- Because the city can't build affordable housing as fast as newcomers arrive, and most can't afford formal rents, many build their own homes on unused land at the edge, so squatter settlements spread.

Common mistake: "Because people want to live in the city." It doesn't say who is coming or why they squat. Name the cause (rural-to-urban migration) and the link (no affordable housing).

Why the model works: It names the cause, gives proof (push and pull factors, growth), and explains the link to housing.

F. Using both stimuli, explain ONE challenge a primate city like Puerto Alba faces in providing services such as clean water, sanitation, or transportation to the zone of peripheral squatter settlements. EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Uses Stimulus 1: the squatter-settlement zone is at the outer edge, far from the CBD
- Uses Stimulus 2: a primate city that grew fast
- Explains the service challenge and its effect

MODEL ANSWER

T1- One challenge is that Puerto Alba is growing faster than it can extend water pipes and sewers to its edge.
E2- Stimulus 2 shows Puerto Alba is a primate city that grew from 5,400,000 to 9,600,000 people since 2000, and Stimulus 1 shows the squatter settlements form the outer ring, farthest from the CBD.
A3- As the squatter-settlement zone spreads onto unplanned land, pipes must stretch ever farther, so many residents go without clean water and sanitation, which spreads diseases like cholera.

Common mistake: "Puerto Alba has a lot of people, so it is crowded." It uses neither stimulus and names no service. Use both: fast growth (Stimulus 2) plus an edge far from the CBD (Stimulus 1).

Why the model works: It uses both stimuli (growth, the edge location), names a service, and explains the effect (disease).

G. Explain ONE way a city government could improve living conditions in informal settlements like those in Puerto Alba's zone of peripheral squatter settlements. EXPLAIN

EARNS THE POINT IF THE ANSWER DOES ALL OF THESE:

- Names a strategy: upgrading, services, land titles, site-and-service, or BRT
- Explains how it improves living conditions

MODEL ANSWER

T1- A city government could upgrade informal settlements in place by adding basic services and giving residents legal titles to their land.
E2- For example, Rio de Janeiro's Favela-Bairro program paved streets, installed water and sewer lines, and built community centers in existing favelas instead of bulldozing them.
A3- Clean water and sewers reduce disease, and families with secure land titles are more likely to invest in improving their homes, which raises living conditions while moving as few families as possible.

Common mistake: “The government should get rid of the slums.” Clearing slums destroys homes and pushes people elsewhere. Name a strategy that helps and explain its effect.

Why the model works: It names a strategy, gives a real example (Favela-Bairro), and explains how lives improve.

Scoring guide written for the GeoArcade FRQ Tutor. Award each part independently, 1 point each.